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About the Author

A HANDBOOK ON
HOLY
SPIRIT
BAPTISM
DON
BASHAM



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A Handbook on Holy Spirit Baptism

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PREFACE

Today, millions of people have been hearing and sharing the new and exciting news of the twentieth-century Pentecost that is sweeping the Christian world. After several years of participating in seminars and conferences here and abroad that have dealt with this outpouring of the Holy Spirit, I discovered that most of them covered much of the same ground and dealt with many of the same primary questions. I also discovered that while a few books and small pamphlets touched on some of these questions, it seemed that no single volume was available whose primary objective was to answer most of them.

The purpose of *A Handbook on Holy Spirit Baptism* is to help fill this need. It deals with those primary questions about seeking and receiving the baptism in the Holy Spirit, as well as the areas that often block an individual from obtaining this blessing from God. Every question that is included is one that has been asked repeatedly in teaching conferences and seminars over the years. Obviously, most of the areas could have been discussed at much greater length, but bear in mind that this is a handbook, not an encyclopedia.

No claim is made for any new revelation in these pages. Most Spirit-baptized readers will have heard or read about most of the points discussed, although some of the illustrative material may be new.

The book is designed primarily for two groups of Christians: (1) those interested in or seeking to receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit, and (2) those who have already received the baptism and now find themselves with opportunity to minister to others.

While all the material is pertinent, this is not a book that requires reading from beginning to end to be of value. That is why it is called a handbook. Instead of giving titles to the chapters, we have simply allowed the question the chapter deals with to serve as its heading. Then, by checking the table of contents, you can quickly turn to the question of greatest interest or concern to you or to those with whom you may be discussing the subject.

Except for quoted material, the responsibility for the contents of the book is mine. No claim is made for infallibility. Other writers would doubtlessly stress different points and include other material in answering the same questions. A prayerful effort has been made to combine clear Scripture teaching with personal experience, but no “in-depth” study or analysis of Scripture has been attempted.

Eloquence has been sacrificed on the altar of plain speech, and most of the material is presented in a conversational manner, as in a public meeting. From time to time, I have drawn on the experiences of others. I gratefully acknowledge my indebtedness to them, but most of all to our Lord Jesus Christ, Who is today revealing Himself not only as Savior and Healer, but also as Baptizer in the Holy Spirit.

PART I

Questions Concerning the Charismatic Movement and the Baptism in the Holy Spirit

immediate, potent presence of God in each human soul and in the Christian Fellowship.

Until lately, other Protestants regarded the movement as a temporary and passing phenomenon, not worth much mention. Now there is a growing, serious recognition of its true dimension and probable permanence. The tendency to dismiss its Christian message as inadequate is being replaced by a chastened readiness to investigate the secrets of its mighty sweep.²

In John Sherrill's book, *They Speak with Other Tongues*, Dr. Van Dusen makes an even more remarkable statement:

I have come to feel...that the Pentecostal movement with its emphasis upon the Holy Spirit, is more than just another revival. It is a revolution in our day. It is a revolution comparable in importance with the establishment of the original Apostolic Church and with the Protestant Reformation.³

The late Reverend Samuel Shoemaker, shortly before his death, published a final article in *The Episcopalian*, a respected publication of the Protestant Episcopal Church in the U.S., entitled, "Can Our Kind of Church Change Our Kind of World?" In it, Shoemaker said:

Whatever the old-new phenomenon of "speaking in tongues" means, it is amazing that it should break out, not only in Pentecostal groups, but among Episcopalians, Lutherans, and Presbyterians. I have not had this experience myself. I have seen people who have, and it has blessed them and given them power they did not have before. I do not profess to understand this phenomenon. But I am fairly sure it indicates the Holy Spirit's presence in a life, as smoke from a chimney indicates a fire below. I know it means God is trying to get through into the church, staid and stuffy and self-centered as it often is, with the kind of power that will make it radiant and exciting and self-giving. We should seek to understand and be reverent toward this phenomenon, rather than to ignore or scorn it.

This rising tide of publicity and literature on the charismatic movement simply points to the ever-increasing influence it is having on Christianity. All over the world the church's spiritual pulse is being quickened by this new Pentecost.

1. Newbigin, *The Household of God* (S.C.M. Press, 1957), pp. 87-88.

2. Used by permission.

3. Sherrill, *They Speak with Other Tongues* (Old Tappan, New Jersey: Flemming H. Revell Co., 1965), p. 30.

Christian baptism by immersion in water:

1. The candidate: the penitent believer (Matthew 28:19; Acts 2:38)
2. The baptismal element: water (Acts 8:36–38)
3. The baptizer: man—a preacher, evangelist, deacon (Acts 8:38)
4. The purpose: a witness to conversion and the remission of sins (Acts 2:38; 22:16)
5. The result: salvation and entry into the body of Christ (Mark 16:16; Galatians 3:27)

Baptism in the Holy Spirit:

1. The candidate: the baptized believer—(Acts 2:38, 8:14–17)
2. The baptismal element: the Holy Spirit—(Mark 1:8)
3. The baptizer: Jesus Christ—(Matthew 3:11; Mark 1:8)
4. The purpose: to endue the Christian with power—(Luke 24:49; Acts 1:8)
5. The result: reception of the Holy Spirit, with accompanying gifts and powers—(Acts 2:4, 8:14–17; 1 Corinthians 12:4–13)

FOUR

Is baptism in the Holy Spirit essential for salvation?

No, baptism in the Holy Spirit is *not* essential for salvation. Salvation, or conversion, or the acceptance of Christ as Lord and Savior, is a separate, prior experience. Millions of Christians who love and serve Jesus Christ as Savior have not received the baptism in the Holy Spirit. The New Testament makes it plain that baptism in the Holy Spirit is a second work of grace, which follows conversion.

Philip went down to a city of Samaria, and proclaimed to them the Christ....But when they believed Philip as he preached good news about the kingdom of God and the name of Jesus Christ, they were baptized, both men and women....Now when the apostles at Jerusalem heard that Samaria had received the word of God, they sent to them Peter and John, who came down and prayed for them that they might receive the Holy Spirit; for it had not yet fallen on any of them, but they had only been baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.

(Acts 8:5, 12, 14–16)

At times, baptism in the Holy Spirit may come immediately following conversion, like in Acts 10, when Peter preached to the household of Cornelius. On that occasion, as Peter preached faith in Christ and forgiveness of sins through His name (see Acts 10:43), those who heard, believed, and were immediately filled with the Holy Spirit (see Acts 10:44–48).

Peter's statement in Acts 2:38 seems to indicate that baptism in the Holy Spirit should immediately follow water baptism. While this may be ideally true and occasionally happens today (a missionary friend related how young converts in Mexico came up out of the baptismal waters praising God in tongues and prophesying), it is not common. Most Christians today receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit only after instructions and specific prayer.

Again, let us state that while we know the baptism in the Holy Spirit to be, an important Christian doctrine and a vastly needed Christian experience for bringing New Testament power back into the church, it is *not* essential for salvation.

FIVE

I had a wonderful conversion experience and assumed I received the Holy Spirit then. Doesn't conversion bring the Holy Spirit?

Certainly the Holy Spirit is present in conversion. Paul says, “*No one can say ‘Jesus is Lord’ except by the Holy Spirit*” (1 Corinthians 12:3). We know that every Christian experiences a measure of the Holy Spirit’s power. But the Scriptures plainly teach there is spiritual power-available beyond our experience of conversion. Obviously, Paul was converted on the road to Damascus, but the Lord sent Ananias to him to pray for him to get his sight back and to *be filled with the Holy Spirit*. (See Acts 9:17). And while the Samaritan Christians were soundly converted under Philip’s teaching, still it was through prayer and the laying on of hands that they received the Holy Spirit. (See Acts 8:14–17).

Let us stress that this deeper experience of the Holy Spirit in no way refutes or denies any experience the Christian may have had before. It simply opens unto us a whole new realm of spiritual possibilities.

Many Christians seem to feel that since their conversion was so wonderful, this must be all that God has for them. Yet, many of those same Christians confess to a lack of boldness and a lack of power.

The baptism in the Holy Spirit is not a saving experience for the non-Christian; it is an empowering experience for the Christian in order that he may be supernaturally equipped to perform his ministry.

Reverend Dennis Bennett observes that in these days of the devil’s wrath it is almost tragic to bring a person to Jesus Christ and stop short of praying him through to the baptism in the Holy Spirit. “It’s like recruiting a man into the army,” Bennett declares, “and not giving him any weapons to fight with. He goes into battle unarmed and may soon end up a prisoner of the enemy.”

Bennett also has a unique way of picturing the difference between the Christian’s *having* the Holy Spirit in conversion and *receiving* Him in terms of the baptism in the Holy Spirit.

“A man may push his way past my secretary and come into my office and sit down while I am very busy at my desk. I know he is there, but continue working, not acknowledging his presence. After a few minutes my telephone rings and someone on the other end of the line asks, ‘Have you a man in your office?’ and proceeds to describe my visitor. I reply, ‘Yes, he’s here, but I haven’t laid aside my work to welcome him. I haven’t *received* him yet.’”

“But then suppose,” Bennett continues, “I lay aside my work and give my visitor a cordial welcome and devote to him my undivided attention and ask him, ‘Why are you here and how may I serve you?’ Then my visitor may rise to his feet with a glad smile and shake my hand and say, ‘Oh, I’m so glad you

finally *received* me, for I have a check for you for one million dollars and I want to give it to you. And I have an important message from a friend whom you haven't seen in a long time, plus so many other good things I want to share with you, *now that you have received me.*"

So it is with many Christians. They have the Holy Spirit present in their lives, but He sits quietly waiting to be *received*. They have not yet made Him fully welcome, nor given Him their full attention, nor tried to discover the purpose of His coming, thus robbing themselves of the gifts and powers He wishes to bestow. They are like the Ephesian disciples whom Paul asked, "*Did you **receive** the Holy Spirit when you believed?*" (Acts 19:2, emphasis added). The baptism in the Holy Spirit is *receiving* Him with power into our lives.

SIX

Is every Christian meant to have the baptism in the Holy Spirit?

The New Testament apostles thought so. “*Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?*” (Acts 19:2) seemed to be a kind of watchword with the early church. And Peter’s plea in Acts 2:38 for both the acceptance of Christ as Lord and the receiving of the Holy Spirit is followed by a universal promise: “*For the promise is to you and to your children and to all that are far off, everyone whom the Lord our God calls to him*” (Acts 2:39).

When Philip’s preaching in Samaria, as recorded in Acts 8, resulted in the conversion of multitudes to Christ, the apostles in Jerusalem quickly sent down Peter and John to minister to the new converts that they might be filled with the Holy Spirit, “*for it had not yet fallen on any of them, but they had only been baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus*” (Acts 8:16).

It is important to note that while the apostles did not doubt the validity of the conversion of the Samaritans, still they were not content to leave them without this further vital experience of the power of God. Today, the majority of Christians seem to fit the description of those Samaritans. They have salvation but not the power to minister and witness which comes with Jesus’ baptism in the Holy Spirit.

If you are a Christian, you can and should have the baptism in the Holy Spirit.

SEVEN

*My minister claims the age of miracles is past
and that the charismatic gifts, including
speaking in tongues and miracles of healing, are
not meant for today.
How can I answer him?*

Well, you can love your minister for his sincerity, but his theology at this point is in error. Most ministers who were trained in liberal Bible colleges and seminaries had this same theory drilled into them. When I say this, I include myself, for I was trained in such a seminary. We need to know how such theories came into being and to realize that they are not based on Scripture. Hebrews 13:8 plainly states, “*Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever.*” As Rufus Moseley used to say, “This means that what Jesus was, He is; what He said, He says; and what He did, He does.” Jesus still saves today, still heals today, still baptizes in the Holy Spirit today, and still performs miracles in answer to prayers of faith today.

The belief that the age of miracles is past is commonly called *dispensationalism*. Dispensationalism claims that God has tried various expedients with man, each one having been completely abandoned before the next one was attempted so that divine workings in one age or dispensation do not apply to the next. This faulty teaching has played literal havoc with the faith of millions of Christians, deluding them into believing that the supernatural power of God which wrought miracles in New Testament days is not available today.

Dispensationalism gained popular support not because the Scriptures back it up but because it seemed to offer a ready excuse for why the church today is not a miracle-working church. It is far easier to claim that the age of miracles is past than to admit that the miraculous power of God is still available but the church lacks the necessary devotion and faith to bring them into manifestation.

Some dispensationalists claim the miracle gifts and powers were withdrawn at the close of the apostolic age (around 100 A.D.), when the last apostle and the last one upon whom an apostle laid his hands had died. The miracle gifts were but a temporary blessing bestowed by God to help get the struggling young church on its feet. Once the church was established, God snatched the power away.

Others claim it was the completion of the New Testament (around 350 A.D.), which signaled the end of miracles. Once the New Testament was complete, God’s revelation was finished, so the Holy Spirit gave up performing miracles and today confines His activity to the written word. This theory has led some rather zealous devotees of this position to hold their New Testaments aloft and boast, “I can buy all the Holy Spirit there is for fifty cents.”

Still others claim the miracles were needed only so long as the early Christians were superstitious and immature and needed “divine signs” to help them believe, but that the mature and enlightened church of today has no need of such signs and wonders. This last argument is so obviously contradicted by the anemic state of current Christianity that no thoughtful person can take it seriously. If there was ever a time when the church and the world stood in greater peril and need, if there was ever a time when the onslaughts of Satan were as great or when evil was running as rampant, history has failed to record it. We need every spiritual gift and power contained in God’s arsenal in order to wage successful spiritual warfare today.

In seeking support for their arguments, dispensationalists often make reference to two passages of Scripture. One is 1 Corinthians 13:8–10: *“As for prophecies, they will pass away; as for tongues, they will cease...when the perfect comes, the imperfect will pass away.”* The coming of “the perfect” is assumed to be the completion of the New Testament. After that, goodbye spiritual gifts!

True, Paul said that the imperfect will pass away. But when? Paul knew nothing of a coming end of the apostolic age, nor of a completed New Testament. In fact, there is nothing in his writings to indicate that he ever assumed there would be a written New Testament. The context makes it clear that the coming of the perfect was to be the return of Christ and the establishment of the kingdom of God on earth, when he (and we) would see Christ “*face to face*” and would “*understand even as we are understood*” (1 Corinthians 13:12).

The other Scripture is 2 Timothy 4:20: *“Trophimus I left ill at Miletus”*, which is offered as scriptural proof that miracles had ceased at that time, since Paul was unable to heal Trophimus. But the fact that everyone prayed for does not receive healing is no more an indication that the miraculous power of God has been withdrawn than the fact that everyone hearing the message of salvation does not accept Christ is an indication that God has withdrawn His power to save. Just as there are many reasons why people do not respond to the gospel message, so there are many reasons why people do not respond miraculously when a prayer for healing is offered. The truth is, multitudes have been saved through preaching and multitudes have been healed of disease, filled with the Holy Spirit, and are today experiencing the supernatural manifestations of the Holy Spirit, even as Jesus promised.

These signs shall follow them that believe; in my name shall they cast out demons, they shall speak with new tongues...they shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall recover.

(Mark 16:17 kjv)

The dispensationalist, having eliminated a miracle-working God from his Christianity, is placed in a painful position when confronted with a miracle of healing. No matter that the one receiving healing glorifies God; no matter that friends and relatives may be brought to Christ through the miracle; no matter that the healing is fully consistent with the teachings of Jesus in the New Testament. The dispensationalist often resorts to the radical explanation of the miracle: “The devil did it.” And in declaring a miracle of God to be a work of Satan, he performs an act of great spiritual danger, for his denunciation borders on blasphemy against the Holy Spirit, the one unforgivable sin.

In Matthew 12, when Jesus healed a blind and dumb demoniac, the Pharisees said, “*It is only by Beelzebub, the prince of demons, that this man casts out demons*” (verse 24), thus attributing a miracle wrought by the Holy Spirit to Satan. Listen to our Lord’s solemn reply:

Therefore I tell you, every sin and blasphemy will be forgiven men, but the blasphemy against the Spirit will not be forgiven. And whoever says a word against the Son of man will be forgiven; but whoever speaks’ against the Holy Spirit will not be forgiven either in this age or in the age to come.

(Matthew 12:31–32)

One final comment on dispensationalism: Rufus Moseley once wisely observed, “If those who insist the age of miracles has ended had lived in Jesus’ day, the age of miracles might never have begun.” In other words, the skeptic who rejects the miracles today would have rejected them in Jesus’ day. Miracles are no more believable simply because they happened hundreds of years ago. Unbelief is still the greatest hindrance to the manifestation of God’s power. It thwarted even the ministry of Jesus when, in his own home town, they refused to believe and “*took offense at him.*”

And he could do no mighty work there...and he marveled because of their unbelief. (Mark 6:5–6)

EIGHT

How do you answer people who claim this experience is not normative to Christianity and that Jesus never spoke in tongues?

Neither argument carries much weight. First of all, how much importance should we place on whether or not a religious practice is currently “normative”? Christianity is not the normative religion of the world today, but this does not keep Christians from proclaiming Jesus Christ as the Light of the world and believing that it is God’s will for all men to come to a saving knowledge of Him. While the baptism in the Holy Spirit may not yet be normative in the church of our day, nevertheless, it is growing by leaps and bounds. It was much more normative in the early church than is generally understood. A study of Scripture shows that Christians in Caesarea, Samaria, Ephesus, Rome, Corinth, and Jerusalem received the Holy Spirit with speaking in tongues since either direct or indirect references point to the fact.

We know that the 120 in the upper room at Pentecost spoke in tongues, as did the apostle Paul. From this group emerged almost the entire leadership of the early church. Obviously, as they ministered in the power of the Holy Spirit, the experience of tongues was a part of what they shared and passed on through prayer and the laying on of hands. Everywhere the Holy Spirit was received, the supernatural gifts, including tongues, followed.

While it is only in Paul’s first Corinthian letter, chapters 12–14, that we find any lengthy discussion or teaching about tongues and the other charismatic gifts, this was not because the Corinthian Christians were the only Christians *experiencing* the gifts, but because they were the only ones *abusing* them.

By comparison, we assume the Lord’s Supper was in widespread use throughout the New Testament church, but it is only in the same epistle, chapters 10–11, that any substantial teaching or instructions are given concerning communion. Here again, it was not use but abuse that led to the instructions. Yet, many Christians who have allowed Paul’s criticism of the improper use of tongues to deny their validity and use in the church today would not dream of allowing Paul’s criticism of the improper administration of the Lord’s Supper to deny their right to the current observance of the Lord’s Supper in their church.

As for the second part of the question, it is true that, so far as we know, Jesus never spoke in tongues. His relationship to the Father was unique and His praise to God perfect. Also, we should remember that speaking in tongues and its companion gift of interpretation are the two unique gifts identified with the age of the Holy Spirit, which was ushered in at Pentecost. (All the other gifts had been manifested before.) What is significant for us to remember is that the baptism in the Holy Spirit, which Jesus Himself bestows, included speaking in tongues. It was Jesus Himself who listed tongues as one of the “signs” that would accompany His followers: *“And these signs will accompany those who*

*believe: in my name they will cast out demons; **they will speak in new tongues***" (Mark 16:17). It was the risen, glorified Jesus who fulfilled His own prophecy, by sending the Holy Spirit with speaking in tongues at Pentecost. The baptism in the Holy Spirit with speaking in tongues was normative in the early church. We pray it will become normative in the church today.

NINE

If the charismatic movement is really a revival sent from God, why is there opposition to it?

God deliver us from the day when the church has no critics and is at peace with the world! The times when the church has been most faithful and powerful have always been times of division, disturbance and criticism. Every great revival has had its critics, and this one is no exception. The outpouring of the Holy Spirit brings great problems because it brings great power. The devil is never content to let God's power go unchallenged.

It is not easy for church members, who for years have been complacent and satisfied in their religious habits, to admit something vital may have been missing from their religion. Norman Vincent Peale once observed in a sermon that the watchword of upper-middle-class Protestantism was "Don't do anything to rock the boat." Well, an outpouring of the Holy Spirit with gifts and powers does just exactly that. It rocks the boat. The witness of a Spirit-filled Christian often brings indictment against church members whose lives are relatively devoid of any spiritual power.

Also, part of the opposition to revival comes from ignorance. Many modern Christians are simply ignorant of scriptural teaching on the Holy Spirit. On becoming familiar with New Testament teaching, many of these same people come to see that what is happening today in this revival is scriptural, and they lose their objections to it.

When confronted by the power of God, we have two choices. One is to claim the revival is false and reject it. The other is to take a receptive stand, respond with joy to what God is doing in our day, and let the revival sweep over us.

TEN

I've seen people who have the baptism in the Holy Spirit and who speak in tongues do and say many unloving things. Doesn't this lack of love show that the fruit of the Spirit is more important than the gifts?

The baptism in the Holy Spirit opens the way to many wonderful gifts of God, but it does not provide instant holiness or perfection. Far from it, we must not confuse the gifts of the Spirit with the fruit of the Spirit. The fruit of the Spirit, which Paul lists in Galatians 5:22–33, is an evidence not of the baptism in the Holy Spirit, but of conversion or the new birth. (See 1 John 3:14.) And it is not always quick to appear in the life of a Christian, even one baptized in the Holy Spirit. Just as one may manifest a measure of the fruit of the Spirit, yet experience none of the charismatic gifts, it is also possible (although not desirable) for one baptized in the Holy Spirit to manifest gifts of the Spirit, yet little fruit. But its very nature fruit takes time to produce. Paul criticized the church at Corinth because he saw little evidence of the *fruit* of the Spirit, yet he said, “*I give thanks to God always for you...that you are not lacking in any spiritual gift*” (1 Corinthians 1:4, 7).

On the other hand, no matter if the fruit of the Spirit is in evidence in the life of the Christian (and ideally this should always be the case), without the baptism in the Holy Spirit, with its attendant gifts, that person is missing out on a great measure of divine power that will equip him or her for a more powerful Christian witness.

Of course, the ideal is for the Christian to be fully manifesting both the gifts and the fruit of the Spirit. To advocate either without the other is to err. The two go hand in hand. This is why we find Paul's beautiful psalm to love in 1 Corinthians 13—and remember, love is a fruit and not a gift of the Spirit—sandwiched neatly in between chapters 12 and 14. Many Christians, though able to quote the 1 Corinthians 13 by memory, remain woefully ignorant of chapters 12 and 14. Paul offers the best of both possible worlds in chapter 14, verse 1, when he says, “*Make love your aim* [or do not be content until you manifest the fruit of the Spirit], *and earnestly desire the spiritual gifts* [or do not seek the fruit alone, but the gifts of the Spirit as well]” (1 Corinthians 14:1). Many Christians seem to read that verse as if it said “*Make love your aim, and earnestly reject spiritual gifts.*” When speaking of the fruit and gifts of the Spirit, what Paul advocates is not either/or but both/and.

The major point to remember in order not to confuse the gifts and fruit of the Spirit is this: the *gifts* are supernaturally bestowed by the Spirit, being miraculously manifested in the believer at a specific time and for a specific purpose. The *fruit* of the Spirit can more accurately be described as traits developing in Christian character, qualities in the Christian's life that—

although made possible only by God's grace—develop and mature slowly.

People who have not yet come to understand the experience of the baptism in the Holy Spirit often cite the faults and weaknesses of Spirit-filled Christians (the lack of the fruit of the Spirit, if you will) as a valid reason for not seeking the baptism. Their criticisms should help to keep us humble. But they should not let such criticisms turn them aside from seeking the supernatural power of God. To do so is as foolish as accepting a non-Christian's criticism of an imperfect Christian as valid proof that there is nothing to Christianity.

Paul's criticism of the abuse of tongues in 1 Corinthians 14 is often used by the skeptic to rule out the exercise of the gifts entirely. But while Paul did criticize the undisciplined display of tongues there, we should remember he was speaking to people who had received the ability to pray in tongues, advising them how to use the manifestation wisely for the building up of the church. He was neither disparaging the proper manifestation of tongues nor suggesting that it be removed from the worship service.

So, my brethren, earnestly desire to prophesy, and do not forbid speaking in tongues; but all things should be done decently and in order. (1 Corinthians 14:39–40)

ELEVEN

Why do Spirit-filled Christians become so talkative about their faith and so aggressive in their witness? Don't they know this embarrasses other Christians?

There is some truth in this observation. At times Spirit-filled Christians are “pushy,” and this may seem unfortunate. But the major cause of this complaint may not be the Spirit-filled, witnessing Christian so much as the lack of conviction or Christian testimony on the part of the lukewarm church member. As Rufus Moseley once dryly observed, “The average spiritual temperature in the church is so low that when a healthy man comes along, everyone thinks he has a fever.”

Often, the change within the life of a person who has received the baptism in the Holy Spirit is so remarkable, he finds it difficult *not* to talk about it. He has something to witness to and it may be hard to keep him quiet. No doubt there are times when enthusiasm may get ahead of wisdom and deep convictions may strain the limits of conventional church behavior. Yet, if such testimony proves embarrassing, the real problem may not lie so much with the one witnessing as with those listening. Why shouldn't Christians share with the world and with one another the glory and power of God? What an indictment on the church of Jesus Christ that many Christians find themselves embarrassed at personal testimony!

A minister friend, Reverend J. P. Murray of West Lorne, Ontario, tells of returning to a former pastorate to visit a family where a grown son was obviously head-over-heels in love. One evening, as they sat talking, Murray turned to the boy. “John,” he asked, “how long have you been in love with Mary?” John blushed furiously. “How did you know I was in love?” he stammered. Murray answered with a smile, “I know because no matter what we may be talking about, somehow you manage to bring Mary's name into the conversation.”

Those who have a dynamic and vital relationship to Jesus Christ through the Holy Spirit are like that. They have a way of including His name in their conversation. It may well prove an embarrassment to lukewarm Christians. It also indicates those who testify may have something wonderful to share.

So they called them and charged them not to speak or teach at all in the name of Jesus. But Peter and John answered them, “Whether it is right in the sight of God to listen to you rather than to God, you must judge; for we cannot but speak of what we have seen and heard.” (Acts 4:18–20)

TWELVE

Many claim that this charismatic movement is just fanaticism. How can you be sure it is from God?

The same claim has been lodged against every revival in the history of Christianity; so there is no reason to expect this current revival will not have its share of critics. It has. Traditionally, the institutional church has been the bulwark of conservatism. Anything new or different is automatically suspect. (Someone has described a conservative as a man who believes that nothing should ever be done for the first time.)

It is not difficult to understand the logic behind the accusation of fanaticism, or that the whole revival is spurious. Institutional leaders have always found it safer to look backward than forward. Prophets and spiritual leaders caught up in fresh moves of the Spirit of God have always suffered persecution until their religious movements eventually gained the respect of society. Then they became heroes and “fathers of the faith.” Until then they were troublemakers and fanatics.

Someone has described a fanatic as “one who has stronger convictions than I have.” The definition has a large element of truth in it. Frankly, we live in an age of “watered-down” Christianity. A man willing to give his life for his country is a patriot. Let the same man confess a willingness to die for Jesus Christ, and he’s a fanatic. The current brand of Christianity hawked by most churches makes few demands on people. It may make an effort to comfort the afflicted, but no effort to afflict the comfortable. The easiest thing in the world to join is the church. It is more difficult to gain membership in most lodges and service organizations than it is to join a church.

With this kind of spirit and background existing in a large part of Christendom, any claim to fresh and vital Christian experience which drastically alters the lives of those involved is bound to be labeled in many corners as “fanaticism.” Lukewarm church members are the modern counterpart of those whom Jesus described in Matthew 13, quoting Isaiah:

You shall indeed hear but never understand, and you shall indeed see but never perceive. For this people’s heart has grown dull, and their ears are heavy of hearing, and their eyes they have closed, lest they should perceive with their eyes, and hear with their ears, and understand with their heart, and turn for me to heal them. (Matthew 13:13–15)

How can you be sure the charismatic movement is from God? Well, if you are willing to apply them, there are several simple tests to help determine the truth. Here are three of them:

1. Is the movement scriptural? Does it coincide with the teachings of the New Testament and the life and practice of the New Testament church? Any movement which claims to be of God and

yet cannot be supported by Scriptures should be suspect.

2. The Scripture says, “*By their fruits you will know them,*” so look at the lives of those involved. Are they better people morally and spiritually than they were before? Are they stronger Christians? Is God more real to them? Are they better witnesses to Jesus Christ?

3. Does the charismatic movement glorify Jesus Christ? If it is really of God and empowered by the Holy Spirit, it will exalt Jesus Christ. Is Jesus Christ occupying a more central position in the lives of those involved in the movement? If so, it is of God.

If the answer to these three questions is yes, then the charismatic movement is of God.

THIRTEEN

Isn't the baptism in the Holy Spirit meant primarily for the unsophisticated believer? Doesn't one have to be of a particular emotional temperament to be receptive to this kind of experience?

No. Peter makes this plain when he told the people on the day of Pentecost:

*Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins; and you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. For the promise is to you and to your children **and to all that are far off, every one** whom the Lord our God calls to him. (Acts 2:38–39, emphasis added)*

Just as every person can know Jesus Christ as Lord and Savior, so we believe every Christian can receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit. It is not an experience for a particular type but for all types. The only prerequisite is that you must be a Christian.

Among the millions of people who have received the baptism in the Holy Spirit in the last few decades, we find representatives of every conceivable profession and walk of life and every emotional temperament and personality type. God is no respecter of persons, nor of social or economic strata. In the ranks of Spirit-filled believers, we find doctors, lawyers, psychiatrists, college professors, scientists, clergymen, military personnel (including admirals and generals), business executives and politicians, laborers, housewives, college students, and children.

Emotional temperament, personality or religious background may play a part in how quickly a Christian yields himself to the Holy Spirit and may have some effect on the physical response to the Spirit's working, but they have no bearing on the spiritual reality or power implicit in the baptism in the Holy Spirit.

The Holy Spirit does not change human personality, but His abiding presence certainly enhances it. The Spirit makes dull people bright and bright people brilliant. And when we see one whose personality was bound and crippled by selfishness and fear set free by the Holy Spirit's power, they may appear to have actually undergone a personality transformation.

But the Holy Spirit is a gentleman. He works in our lives only to the extent that we are willing. He prompts and leads and woos and persuades, but He does not force. To become a Christian a person must will or want to accept Christ, and he can. To be filled with the Holy Spirit a Christian must will or want to receive, and he can. Baptism in the Holy Spirit is available for every Christian, regardless of personality traits or temperament.

FOURTEEN

If the miraculous gifts are meant for today, why can't we empty all the hospitals and sick beds and provide miraculous answers for all the needs of mankind?

This is a question commonly bandied about among Christians who feel the age of miracles is past. Its weakness lies in the implication that the miracle-working power of God is like magic, and that the signs and wonders of God's power can be divorced from the gospel message. Let us recast the same question in terms of salvation: If Jesus is the Son of God with power to save, why isn't the whole world Christian? The immediate answer is that salvation is dependent upon man's response to the gospel message.

Potentially, what both questions ask is possible, for potentially, every human need has been met in the grace of God revealed through the atonement of Jesus Christ. Christ died for *all* men. The intent of God to establish a society on earth where every need is met through His love and grace is clearly revealed in New Testament teaching. It is called the kingdom of God. Jesus demonstrated it in His ministry, proclaimed its proximity, and we pray for its manifestation every time we pray the Lord's Prayer: "*Thy kingdom come...on earth.*"

But we must also recognize that *the promises of God are conditional*. They require the surrender of man's will to the will of God. Man's full response in faith to the promises of God involves submission and obedience. In fact, it necessitates a kind of death; a crucifixion of the old nature that the divine life and nature of Jesus Christ may be formed in us.

We find no basis in Scripture for assuming that the blessings and miracles of God are automatic, or that they will be bestowed upon those who are unbelieving, indifferent, or unrepentant and who have neither sought God's will nor surrendered their lives to Him. God's blessings are contingent upon man's repentance and surrender, and his turning to God in prayer and faith. As the Lord reminded Solomon,

If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face, and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven, and will forgive their sin and heal their land. (2 Chronicles 7:14)

The time may soon be upon us when mass healing miracles will result in the emptying of entire hospitals. This has already been seen in vision and promised by the Lord in prophecy. It is an established fact that even today, where great revivals are in progress—such as the one in Indonesia—mass healing miracles have already taken place.

Miracles of healing and other supernatural evidences of the power of God are the "signs" that, from the age of the apostles, were meant to follow "*those who believe*" (Mark 16:17). Today, we find them occurring with ever-increasing frequency and believe they foreshadow

the sinless and miraculous kingdom, which Jesus Christ will set up on earth when He returns.

FIFTEEN

Can one receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit and not be aware that he has received it?

Generally speaking, the answer to this question is no, one cannot receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit and not know he has received it. But to be more precise, we must qualify that answer in three ways:

1. On rare occasions people *have* received the baptism in the Holy Spirit with speaking in tongues and, although they knew something strange and wonderful had taken place, did not know what had happened to them. They had never heard of the baptism in the Holy Spirit and so had no way to define the experience. In such cases, the baptism usually comes in some deep moment of prayer or during a time of spontaneous praise to God.

We know one friend who went forward in a meeting for what she thought was to be prayer for healing. She had misunderstood the minister's invitation, which had been for those seeking the baptism in the Holy Spirit. As she sat in the appointed place, people gathered around and began praying for her. Suddenly, she felt her tongue begin to thrash around in her mouth and found herself speaking in tongues in the midst of a glorious feeling of love and power. But it was only after friends had explained her experience that she understood what had happened. But again, let us stress that such experiences are rare.

2. A second part of the answer is directed to yet another group of people. There are those Christians who seem to feel that the baptism in the Holy Spirit is a blessing that God mysteriously and secretly bestows, here and there. They may wonder if, at some time in their Christian walk or experience, they received this blessing without being aware of it. They wonder if they received the baptism when they accepted Christ or at some point when they made a special commitment to God. I believe it is fairly safe to say to all such persons, "If you doubt that you've received the baptism in the Holy Spirit, you haven't." This encounter with God's Holy Spirit is too charged with divine life and power for us to take it for granted or to assume it came to us unnoticed. And this is one of the reasons we look for the manifestation of speaking in tongues. It is concrete evidence that the person speaking has been baptized in the Holy Spirit.

3. A third part of the answer to this question deals with those who have actively sought the baptism in the Holy Spirit, have received prayer for the baptism and have even spoken a strange word or two

in tongues, but doubt that they have really received the baptism. Many, many people experience this problem. They have received the baptism but are not yet sure of their experience. They haven't spoken as fluently as their friends do, or their experience has not measured up to their expectations. If this is your situation, then let me assure you, yes, you have received the baptism in the Holy Spirit, but the devil is trying to talk you out of it. If you've spoken so much as one syllable in tongues, claim your experience by faith and persevere in prayer until you become fluent in your new language of praise.

So, to summarize, on rare occasions, God does baptize people in the Holy Spirit, and they do not know what happened, except that it was wonderful. Second, if a person has never sought the baptism, never spoken in tongues, yet wonders if maybe God baptized him without him being aware of it, no, he has *not* received. But third, when a person actively seeks the baptism and is prayed for, he may receive and even speak a few words in an unknown tongue, yet doubts, then yes, he has received, but the devil is doing his dead-level best to talk him out of it.

SIXTEEN

Why is it that people baptized in the Holy Spirit are not in agreement on all points of doctrine?

The baptism in the Holy Spirit always results in significant changes in the theology of those who receive it, for the overwhelming reality of the Holy Spirit tends to make many previously held beliefs and doctrines insignificant. But we should remember that the baptism in the Holy Spirit is to be equipped with power for Christian service, not a ticket to omniscience. At many points, Spirit-filled Christians differ. But they are 100 percent in agreement on the importance and significance of the baptism in the Holy Spirit.

Even the apostles did not always agree. (See Acts 15; Galatians 2:1–15.) As great and wise as Paul was, he still admitted, “*For now we see in a mirror dimly....Now I know in part*” (1 Corinthians 13:12). Yet, in spite of differences, there is a very precious fellowship and unity created among people baptized in the Holy Spirit. It is a unity born of the Holy Spirit and sustained by the Holy Spirit. Many of us believe it is in the charismatic movement that the greatest hope for true Christian unity lies.

One of the delights of receiving the baptism in the Holy Spirit is the freedom it brings concerning denominationalism. The bond of fellowship created by baptism in the Holy Spirit tends to overshadow denominational differences and unite Christians at a level beyond their reach. I personally know Baptists, Methodists, Episcopalians, Lutherans, Congregationalists, Disciples of Christ, Presbyterians, Nazarenes, Pentecostal members of several varieties, as well as members of the United Church of Canada, Brethren, Moravian, Amish, and Roman Catholics, all of whom are Spirit-filled. And when we meet and have fellowship, the dominant concern is not which denomination is right but rather, “How can we tell more people of the love of Jesus and the power of His Holy Spirit?”

SEVENTEEN

What is the baptism in the Holy Spirit meant to accomplish in us?

Essentially, the baptism in the Holy Spirit is a doorway leading from a natural realm into a supernatural realm of life and experience. The average Christian, although truly professing Christ, operates largely on his own power, making his own decisions, living by his own strength, and controlling his own life. But through the baptism in the Holy Spirit, the Christian steps out of this natural realm into a realm where he can begin to experience the *supernatural* gifts and powers of God's Holy Spirit.

The initial evidence of entering this supernatural realm is the ability to speak in other tongues. (See Part II for a discussion of tongues.) But that is just the beginning. If all that happened to the 120 people at Pentecost had been that they began to speak in tongues, their experience would soon have been forgotten. The same is true today. If all that happens to one receiving the baptism in the Holy Spirit is that he speaks in tongues, then he is not forging ahead in faith into this powerful new realm in which God has ushered him. There are many other benefits and blessings awaiting him. The list that follows draws on the testimonies of many Spirit-filled Christians. While it is a typical list, it is by no means exhaustive.

1. Baptism in the Holy Spirit often brings a stronger assurance of salvation.

Jesus said, *"Unless one is born anew, he cannot see the kingdom of God"* (John 3:3). Many Christians, when they accept Jesus Christ as Savior, experience a deep conversion and the assurance that they belong to Christ. But for countless others, the assurance of their born-again experience does not occur until they are baptized in the Holy Spirit. As Paul said, *"When we cry 'Abba, Father!' it is the Spirit himself bearing witness with our spirit that we are the children of God"* (Romans 8:15–16).

Today, many members of the mainline Christian denominations, on hearing of the possibility of a more powerful, personal relationship with Jesus, have sought and found it through the baptism in the Holy Spirit.

The following testimony of one who recently received the baptism in the Holy Spirit is typical of many:

For years I had been a faithful church member. I came to worship; I listened to sermons; I worked on committees; I served in every way I knew how; yet I was not satisfied. When I heard about the baptism in the Holy Spirit, I knew this was something I really needed. And when I received it, Jesus became much more real to me. Everything changed! I began to love people. The church services suddenly came to life. All the hymns and prayers became almost unbearably sweet. The sermons sounded as if we had a new minister, only he had been saying the same things all along. I was the one who was changed.

Yet, trying to explain this experience to those who have not experienced it themselves can be as difficult as trying to describe hot weather to Eskimos. In churches where worship and service are based on an intellectual assent to the gospel, where fellowship is determined by social and economic ties rather than on the common experience of personal redemption, the testimony of a Spirit-filled Christian—whose heart has been melted in the flame of a profoundly moving encounter with the risen Lord as Baptizer and King—may be completely misunderstood or rejected. The lukewarm church member cannot really understand it until it happens to him.

2. Baptism in the Holy Spirit brings a further crucifixion of the “old self.”

The baptism in the Holy Spirit brings with it a new spiritual sensitivity—a sensitivity that works in more ways than one. Just as we become more aware of God’s presence within us, so do we also become more aware of the presence of sin. This increased sensitivity to sin is matched by a desire for personal holiness—but while the spirit is willing, the flesh is often weak.

Potentially, we die to the old nature when we become Christians.

We know that our old self was crucified with him so that the sinful body might be destroyed and we might no longer be enslaved to sin. (Romans 6:6)

The realization of this crucifixion of the “old self” in our actual experience is another matter. While one may experience immediate deliverance from a particular illness, addiction, or personal weakness as a result of being baptized in the Holy Spirit, and while new and unmistakable joy and power enter into one’s life, still the battle against the “old self” continues to be waged in other areas of our lives. *There is no such thing as instant holiness.*

A friend, Enid Newman, once shared an experience that illustrates this point. One day, while she was earnestly praying for God to make her more tolerant and loving, the Holy Spirit prompted her to claim a particular passage of Scripture as a personal promise, Ezekiel 36:26: “*A new heart I will give you...I will take out of your flesh the heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh.*” As she claimed the Scripture, she felt a new and precious love stealing into her heart and became quite excited over what she thought was to be an instantaneous spiritual transformation. But then, in a vision, she saw a picture of her heart. It was like a wagon load of junk metal—dirty, rusted, and useless. As she gazed at it in dismay, she saw one small piece of metal begin to shimmer until it became like purest gold. The Holy Spirit witnessed to her that this was the transformation she had just experienced, and that, as she continued to surrender to Him, little by little, He would continue to make her heart new and pure.

The crucifixion of the old self, which begins with rebirth and is intensified by the baptism in the Holy Spirit, is a long and painful process. They may be right who claim that this purging is the “fire” John the Baptist spoke of when he said Jesus would baptize “*with the Holy Spirit and with fire*” (Luke 3:16). We would be less than honest to claim that such an inflow of spiritual power has no crucifying element within it. It has! But the joy of being in the Vine enables us to endure the pruning of the Vinedresser.

3. Baptism in the Holy Spirit brings the Scriptures to life.

which seemed to point in the direction of the university. Growing tired and irritable, we were tempted, several times, to give up the whole venture and return home. The time for the meeting arrived and we were nowhere near our destination. Then, to make matters worse, we found ourselves on an expressway leading us past the university but with no exit to the campus, making it necessary to drive several miles before we could turn around and make our way back. By this time, I was exasperated enough to regret I'd ever heard of the Christian faith in general and the charismatic movement in particular.

Finally, we found ourselves on the campus, where a helpful student gave us directions to the building where the seminar was being held. It was now almost an hour past the scheduled time of meeting. As we pulled alongside the curb, we were relieved to find two parking spaces adjacent to front of the entrance—the only two spaces in an otherwise unbroken line of parked cars. As I pulled into one space, a small sedan followed me into the second space. We climbed from the car and were astounded to see Harald Bredesen emerging from the other car. Through circumstances unknown to us, he, too, had been delayed. While those responsible for the seminar scattered over the campus to gather the students and faculty, Victor, Harald, and I sat on the front steps and had a leisurely half-hour to discuss those things that were most important to us, and to marvel at how—in the midst of confusion and complaint—the Holy Spirit had worked to bring us together.

Other times, the Holy Spirit will move with urgency to get us into the will of God for a particular purpose. Several years ago, while serving at a church in Toronto, Canada, I experienced such an incident. I was mowing the parsonage lawn one Saturday afternoon when, under an unusual prompting of the Holy Spirit, I was moved to go attend a service at a healing revival being conducted in the west end of that city. On the way to the service, the Holy Spirit directed me to a hospital where one of my deacons lay recovering from surgery. As I approached the hospital, the Spirit revealed that I would find the deacon near death and was to take his name to the healing service, request prayer for his healing, and stand in as his proxy for the laying on of hands. True to the Spirit's leading, I found the deacon near death, continued on to the healing service, and stood in proxy for prayer and the laying on of hands in his behalf. God stayed the hand of death and the deacon recovered.

At times, this kind of prompting of the Holy Spirit seems so in conflict with our own natural desires, and at other times our plans seem so in conflict with His desires that we are reluctant to yield in obedience. Often, the Holy Spirit must thwart our plans in order to make us receptive to His. This was true in the early church.

*And they went through the region of Phrygia and Galatia, having been forbidden by the Holy Spirit to speak the word in Asia. And when they had come opposite Mysia, **they attempted to go into Bithynia, but the Spirit of Jesus did not allow them**; so, passing by Mysia, they went down to Troas. (Acts 16:6–8, emphasis added)*

The Holy Spirit also gently teaches us that we alone are not responsible for the whole world. There are certain conditions and persons not in our personal “bundle” who—for reasons known only to God—are not in our province to

help. A close study of the ministry of Jesus indicates He was subject to the discriminating guidance and direction of the Holy Spirit. While He loved all men and never refused to help or heal anyone who came seeking Him, still, He did not force His ministry on people who were neither interested in Him nor ready to believe His message. For example, when He visited the Bethesda pool where there lay a whole crowd of sick people, He was led by the Holy Spirit to minister only to one man. (See John 5:1–9.)

5. Baptism in the Holy Spirit gives more power in prayer.

The church as a whole seems still asleep to the fact that earnest, believing prayer is the channel through which the miracle-working power of God flows. Many church members—and ministers, as well—freely admit that intercessory prayer has no place in their lives. I remember the shock and dismay I felt when I heard the admission of a seminary professor—an former navy chaplain and an ordained minister in my own denomination—frankly confess that he’d never in all his life seen anything happen, either to him or to anyone else, that would give him any assurance that God heard and answered prayer. Early in our spiritual journey, my wife and I began to experience definite and sometimes dramatic answers to prayer. It is still a matter of deep concern with us how few Christians avail themselves of this powerful weapon. After twenty years of trusting Him, we couldn’t begin to count the times God has lovingly and graciously answered our petitions.

Just yesterday, we experienced His love and bounty in this way. For several days we had been holding before Him a pressing financial obligation that totaled \$94.28. We simply had no money with which to pay this obligation and knew of no source where such a sum would be forthcoming within the immediate future. Nevertheless, we prayed, trusting God, reminding Him of His promise to us that as long as we faithfully sought to minister in accordance with His will, He would provide for our needs. Then, in yesterday’s mail came two checks from completely unexpected sources that totaled \$95.00, and we rejoiced, not only in God meeting our need, but in doing with so exact an amount that there could be no question that He was a loving Father answering a specific request made by His children.

Thus, we see that Jesus’ statements about prayer’s power are not simply “flashes of brilliant hyperbole,” as one biblical critic rationalized, but instead, are firm declarations of what God can and will do in response to believing, trusting prayer.

And the baptism in the Holy Spirit clearly adds a deeper dimension to prayer. The ability to pray in tongues brings with it a new spiritual freedom and creates a precious intimacy with Jesus not previously known. When uncertain how to pray in a given situation, the Spirit-filled Christian may slip over into praying in tongues with the confidence that such Spirit-directed prayer is more effective than his own intellectually-guided efforts. As Paul reminds us:

Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness; for we do not know how to pray as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with sighs too deep for words. And he who searches the hearts of men knows what is the mind of the Spirit, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints according to the will of God.

(Romans 8:26–27)

6. Baptism in the Holy Spirit opens our eyes to the reality of Satan and his power.

Baptism in the Holy Spirit opens the Christian's eyes, not only to the supernatural realities of God, but to the dominion of demons, as well. The battle lines between good and evil, between God and Satan, are much more clearly drawn. Satan is no figment of an overactive imagination to be explained away by religious sophisticates. He is, as Jesus knew him to be, a personal adversary, real and cunning.

In Matthew 4:1–11, we have the account of Jesus' own temptation by the devil at the beginning of His ministry. The temptations were subtle and powerful, offered in terms of Jesus' special powers, tempting Him to achieve a quick and easy victory. Jesus met and overcame the tempter by a reliance on the Word of God. While the encounter was obviously a deeply personal and private experience, nevertheless, it found its way into our New Testament because Jesus shared it with His disciples, and so with us, that we might know and be warned of Satan's disruptive ministry.

The Scriptures clearly reveal that our sin, illness, poverty, and fear are all the result of Satan's oppression. Jesus never once told anybody that sickness was from God; He recognized it and treated it for what it is: an affliction from the devil, to be cast out and destroyed by the power of the Holy Spirit. *"The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I came that they may have life, and have it abundantly"* (John 10:10). *"God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power; how he went about doing good and healing all that were oppressed by the devil, for God was with him"* (Acts 10:38). *"The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil"* (1 John 3:8).

Paul tells us,

For we are not contending against flesh and blood, but against the principalities, against the powers, against the world rulers of this present darkness, against the spiritual hosts of wickedness in the heavenly places. (Ephesians 6:12)

One of the amazing ministries Spirit-filled Christians are finding themselves engaged in is that of casting out demons. We have discovered that many forms of illness, both physical and mental, are the direct result of demonic oppression, and that, in such cases, deliverance lies not in the prayer of faith but in taking authority over the demons in Jesus' name and commanding them to come out. The results are often quite remarkable.

In many cases, the demons manifest themselves in the person just as they did in New Testament times, by taking over and speaking through the individual. They may argue or cajole or plead or insist on their right to be in the person. In the beginning, they may refuse to come out and may curse or threaten the one taking authority over them. On command, they must name themselves, and the name usually reveals their sphere of activity. While engaged in this ministry, I have personally confronted demons who gave such names as Pride, Hatred, Lies, Murder, Anger, Misery, Resentment, Loneliness, Laziness, Silliness, Gluttony, Self-destruction, Meanness, Madness, Lust, Infirmary, Blindness, Dumbness, Self-Pity, Thievery, Wantonness, Blasphemy, Shyness, Profanity, Vanity, and many others.

EIGHTEEN

What is the evidence of the baptism in the Holy Spirit?

The only clear *scriptural* evidence of the baptism in the Holy Spirit is speaking in tongues. The first Christians to be baptized in the Holy Spirit were the 120 gathered in the upper room at Pentecost. The unique evidence that the 120 received the Holy Spirit was that “*they began to speak in other tongues*” (Acts 2:4). All the other spiritual gifts, such as healing and prophecy, appear in the Old Testament and in the gospels. But with the descent of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost, which signified God’s presence in the disciples’ lives in a new dimension, God gave a new gift: the gift of tongues.

The book of Acts records five separate occasions when the Holy Spirit was received. On three of these occasions, speaking in tongues is specifically mentioned as the visible sign accompanying the experience: at Pentecost (see Acts 2:4), at the house of Cornelius (see Acts 10:44–46), and at Ephesus (see Acts 19:6). Paul received the Holy Spirit when Ananias laid hands on him and prayed (see Acts 9:17), and, while tongues are not mentioned at that point, we know they were a part of Paul’s spiritual experience by his own testimony: “*I thank God that I speak in tongues more than you all*” (1 Corinthians 14:18). The fifth occasion was the receiving of the Holy Spirit in Samaria. (See Acts 8:14–17.) Philip had made converts there, and the apostles in Jerusalem had sent Peter and John to him to pray for their baptism in the Holy Spirit. While tongues are not directly identified in the account here, there was some *visible* evidence that made Simon the magician want to purchase the ability to transmit the Holy Spirit from the apostles. Many biblical authorities agree that what Simon saw must have included speaking in tongues.

Then, there is the statement of Jesus in Mark 16:17–18, where tongues are listed along with other supernatural manifestations which were to follow the ministry of believers.

*And these signs will accompany those who believe: in my name they will cast out demons; **they will speak in new tongues**...they will lay their hands on the sick, and they will recover.*

So, according to Scripture, the identifying evidence or sign of receiving the baptism in the Holy Spirit is that of speaking in tongues. While there may be, and frequently are, other spiritual manifestations that accompany the experience of receiving the Holy Spirit, speaking in tongues remains the primary *initial* evidence.

your claim. But when you witness to me that you do speak in tongues, I rejoice because your experience is fully consistent with Scripture.

We encourage everyone seeking to be filled with the Holy Spirit to *seek the baptism on scriptural terms*, fully expecting to speak in tongues when they receive.

Those who ask the question, “Do I *have* to speak in tongues?” make it sound as if they are being asked to swallow an unpleasant dose of medicine. Their question indicates that they believe speaking in tongues is something to be endured rather than enjoyed! Speaking in tongues is a blessed experience! It is a joy and a privilege to be able to communicate with the Lord in this new and exciting manner. Someone has rightly said, “You don’t *have* to speak in tongues; you *get* to!” Or, as Dr. David du Plessis commented, “You don’t have to, but you will.”

Any person receiving the baptism in the Holy Spirit *can*, from the moment he or she accepts the Holy Spirit into his or her life in this new and powerful way, speak in tongues. The actual physical process is discussed elsewhere in this book. But rest assured that anyone filled with the Holy Spirit *can* speak in tongues.

Sometimes, one receiving the baptism may refuse—because of shyness or fear or false teaching—to yield his tongue and lips at the moment he receives the Spirit and so is robbed of this blessing for days or even weeks. But time and again, we have heard the testimony of such persons upon eventually yielding and receiving tongues. They admit that had they not resisted or backed away, they would have spoken in tongues the moment they received the baptism in the Holy Spirit.

TWENTY

What is “speaking in tongues”?

Speaking or praying in tongues is a form of prayer in which the Christian yields himself to the Holy Spirit and receives from the Spirit a supernatural language with which to praise God. It is a miraculous manifestation of God’s power, but one which combines both human and divine elements that expresses both human and divine initiative. It is truly a cooperative effort between the Christian and the Holy Spirit.

Many people misunderstand what takes place when they hear someone praying or speaking in tongues. They are apprehensive over what might happen to them if they “let themselves go like that” or “let some other power take over.” They assume the person is completely passive and that the Holy Spirit is doing it all. This is an erroneous impression of what is taking place. The person himself is actively participating in the experience. As someone once put it, “Without the Holy Spirit, you can’t, but without you, the Holy Spirit won’t.”

Simply stated, man does the speaking; the Holy Spirit furnishes the words. Acts 2:4 says, “*They were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance.*” A free translation might read, “they...began to speak as the Spirit gave them words to say.”

Speaking in tongues is a way of praying that liberates the spirit within and strengthens the Christian in a wonderful manner. The primary purpose of it is for use in one’s own devotional life. Careful restrictions are placed upon its public use. (See 1 Corinthians 14:18–19, 27–28.)

Further information and instruction will be discussed in chapter 36.

TWENTY-ONE

*Don't the Scriptures like **"Do all speak with tongues?"** (1 Corinthians 12:30) and **"If any speak in tongues, let there be only two or at most three"** (1 Corinthians 14:27) indicate that not all Christians are meant to speak in tongues?*

Certainly, this has been used as an extensive argument by those who oppose speaking in tongues. In fact, many use Paul's statement, "*let there be only two or at most three*," not to *limit* tongues but to *prohibit* them entirely. Both these Scriptures must be considered in any discussion of tongues, but only in connection with Paul's statement in 1 Corinthians 14:5: "*Now I want you all to speak in tongues.*" How do we reconcile, "*let there be only two or at most three*" and "*I want you **all** to speak*"? Is Paul contradicting himself? No.

The confusion is cleared away when we consider the two sets of circumstances in which speaking in tongues appear in the New Testament. They appear both as a *sign* and as a *gift*. They appear as a *sign* or outward evidence that accompanies the baptism in the Holy Spirit in Acts 2:4, 10:45–46, 19:6, and Mark 16:17. They appear as a *gift* in Paul's references in 1 Corinthians 12 and 14.

Now in Acts, where tongues appear as a *sign*, all who received the baptism in the Holy Spirit spoke in tongues.

No limitation or restriction is placed on the manifestation, nor is there any suggestion that some received tongues while others did not. Nor is there any attempt to teach or instruct the recipients in the "proper use" of tongues. Speaking in tongues came to all, serving as the *sign*, or evidence, of the Holy Spirit's arrival in power upon them. I believe it is safe and correct to say that there is no such thing as misuse of tongues when they initially appear at the time of one's receiving the baptism in the Holy Spirit.

But in 1 Corinthians 12 and 14, we find Paul discussing speaking in tongues as a *gift* among other gifts, to be used in the services of the church, only as the Holy Spirit directs, for "*the common good*" (1 Corinthians 12:7). Here, Paul treats speaking in tongues not in terms of *receiving* but in terms of *exercising* the ability at a given time in the service of worship. He was explaining to those who had received the *sign* of tongues when they were baptized in the Holy Spirit, and who could now manifest this ability to praise God in other languages, how, *in church*, any manifestation of tongues should fall in the same category as other manifestations of the Spirit, such as prophecy, the word of wisdom, etc. Paul made it clear that, *in church*, if some individual is moved by the Holy Spirit to manifest tongues, it should be accompanied by the gift of interpretation so that the whole worshiping assembly may benefit by it. (See 1

Corinthians 14:27.) Yet, even here, Paul qualifies his statement by adding that prayer in tongues *without interpretation*, i.e., the sign tongue, may also be exercised during the church service, but only *silently*, so as not to disturb or disrupt the public worship service. (See 1 Corinthians 14:28.)

Certainly, in regard to speaking in tongues aloud, in church, with the gift of interpretation to follow, the question, “Do all speak with tongues?” must be answered with an emphatic no!

However, when we encourage those seeking the baptism in the Holy Spirit to seek it in terms of the initial scriptural evidence of speaking in tongues, we do not assume that all receiving tongues will be led by the Spirit to manifest the gift in a public worship service. Experience indicates that only a small percentage of those who manifest speaking in tongues at the time they receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit will ever be used for a public manifestation of tongues and interpretation in church. By far, the most common use of tongues is during one’s own private prayer time.

Essentially, what we have said here is: the accounts in the book of Acts show how the baptism in the Holy Spirit with speaking in tongues is received, while much of Paul’s instructions in 1 Corinthians show how speaking in tongues is to be properly used and controlled in public services of the church.

TWENTY-TWO

Why should I speak in tongues?

The most obvious answer to this question is that the Scriptures encourage it. Jesus said it was one of the signs that was to follow the ministry of Christians: *“And these signs will accompany those who believe...they will speak in new tongues”* (Mark 16:17). And Paul, while recognizing the need for propriety in the public manifestation of tongues, nevertheless urged Christians to receive and make use of this significant gift. *“Earnestly desire the spiritual gifts....Now I want you all to speak in tongues....I thank God that I speak in tongues more than you all”* (1 Corinthians 14:1, 5, 18). As the late Reverend Samuel Shoemaker observed, “The Christian needs every gift God offers.”

The willingness to yield our tongues to God may also indicate a more profound surrender than almost any other act. The tongue is the primary instrument of expression of the human personality, and until God has dominion over the tongue, His control over us is relatively slight.

So the tongue is a little member and boasts of great things. How great a forest is set ablaze by a small fire! And the tongue is a fire. The tongue is an unrighteous world among our members, staining the whole body, setting on fire the cycle of nature, and set on fire by hell. For every kind of beast and bird, of reptile and sea creature, can be tamed and has been tamed by humankind, but no human can tame the tongue—a restless evil, full of deadly poison. (James 3:5–8)

In addition, experience shows that prayer in tongues, which the Scriptures also refer to as *“prayer in the Spirit”* (see 1 Corinthians 14:14–15; Ephesians 6:18), enables us to pray with an ability and authority not our own. We do not always know how to pray in a given situation, but, holding the need up to the Father, we pray in tongues, knowing that our prayers are guided by the Holy Spirit.

When we cry, “Abba! Father!” it is the Spirit himself bearing witness with our spirit that we are children of God....Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness; for we do not know how to pray as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with sighs too deep for words. And he who searches the hearts of men knows what the mind of the Spirit is, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints according to the will of God.

(Romans 8:15–16, 26–27)

Why speak in tongues? Because it grants the Christian a freedom in prayer that enables him to praise God extravagantly, beyond the limiting confines of known speech. Our Lord had nothing but praise for those who have worshiped Him extravagantly, or served or trusted him extravagantly—the poor widow who gave God all the money she had (see Luke 21:1–4), the Roman centurion and his tremendous faith in Jesus’ healing power (see Matthew 8:5–13), and Mary, who was extravagant in her devotion in anointing Him with precious ointment (see John 12:3). Yet, many of us are so stingy and pinched in our relationship with God that any real freedom in prayer or worship is beyond us. Such freedom can come through praying in tongues.

It may help also to realize that there are strong biblical reasons for speaking in tongues. Dr. Henry Ness, in his booklet “The Baptism with the Holy Spirit,” lists twenty Bible reasons for speaking in tongues.

1. 1. Speaking with tongues as the Holy Spirit gives the utterance is the unique spiritual gift identified with the church of Jesus Christ. Prior to the day of Pentecost, all other gifts, miracles, and spiritual manifestations had been in evidence during the Old Testament times. On the Day of Pentecost, this new phenomenon came into evidence and became uniquely identified with the church. (See Acts 2:4; 1 Corinthians 12 and 14.)
2. 2. Speaking with tongues was ordained by God for the church. (See 1 Corinthians 12:28, 14:21.)
3. 3. Speaking with tongues is a specific fulfillment of prophecy. (See Isaiah 28:11; Joel 2:28–29; Acts 2:16–18; 1 Corinthians 14:21.)
4. 4. Speaking with tongues is a sign *of* the believer. (See Mark 16:17; John 7:38–39.)
5. 5. Speaking with tongues is a sign *to* the unbeliever. (See 1 Corinthians 14:22.)
6. 6. Speaking with tongues is a proof of the resurrection and glorification of Jesus Christ. (See John 16:7; Acts 2:22–24, 32–33.)
7. 7. Speaking with tongues is an evidence of the baptism with the Holy Spirit. (See Acts 2:4, 10:45–46, 19:6.)
8. 8. Speaking with tongues is a means of preaching to men of other languages (Acts 2:6–11.)
9. 9. Speaking with tongues is a spiritual gift for self-edification. (See 1 Corinthians 14:4.)
10. 10. Speaking with tongues is a spiritual gift for spiritual edification for the church. (See 1 Corinthians 14:5.)
11. 11. Speaking with tongues is a spiritual gift for communication with God in private worship. (See 1 Corinthians 14:2.)
12. 12. Speaking with tongues is a means by which the Holy Spirit intercedes through us in prayer. (See Romans 8:26; 1 Corinthians 14:14.)
13. 13. Speaking with tongues is a spiritual gift for “singing in the Spirit.” (See Ephesians 5:18–19; 1 Corinthians 14:15.)

the Bible in reference to a speaker in tongues. Those who hear a speaker in tongues are sometimes described as “ecstatic” or “amazed” (existanto in Acts 2:7; exestesan in Acts 10:45) but the speaker himself is never described in this way. These misleading terms occur frequently in commentaries and even in versions of the Bible, but there is no basis for this in the Bible text itself. This seems to be an assumption of the commentators, who perhaps had not had the experience and are, therefore, at a disadvantage in describing the subjective aspects.

There is nothing in the nature of speaking in tongues which is, per se, “ecstatic.” It is, as the Bible so accurately puts it, simply “a speaking.” It has the same emotional potential (and the same possibility of self-control) as speech or prayer in one’s native tongue. The terms “ecstatic utterance” and “tongues of ecstasy” should be abandoned in reference to speaking in tongues. We should use the terms the Bible uses: “speaking in tongues” or “praying in the spirit.”

The idea that one has to become “ecstatic” or go into a trance or “lose control” in order to receive the Holy Spirit or manifest His gifts is simply not true. While emotional excesses may be indulged in by certain fringe groups, the fact is that most people receiving the baptism in the Holy Spirit today receive it among people who worship in churches similar to their own and whose religious backgrounds are compatible with theirs. God does not require us to be any other kind of person than who we are in order to be filled with His Spirit. Almost without exception, this kind of question comes from people who have not had the experience. It is only natural that they should defend their position by gathering as many objections as they can. Most persons who have received the Holy Spirit with speaking in tongues once held such views themselves. I did. But once you receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit, once you speak in tongues yourself, you will understand how unfounded the fears and objections are.

to preach to the assembled multitude, he spoke in his own native tongue.

However, there are frequent cases today where the tongues spoken by a Spirit-filled believer are in a language unknown to him but recognized by one listening. Such incidents do serve to prove the supernatural nature of the experience.

An Indian student in Washington, D.C., shared with me this interesting story. A minister who opposed the work of Pentecostal missionaries in India wrote a pamphlet denouncing the experience of speaking in tongues. In it, he quoted a single phrase he had heard as “meaningless gibberish.” Disciples of the writer took copies of the pamphlet to distribute in various villages where the Pentecostal missionaries were at work. Standing in the center of a particular village, one pamphleteer began denouncing the Pentecostal experience. He read aloud the example of “gibberish” included in the pamphlet only to have a local man push his way excitedly through the crowd and ask him to repeat the phrase. Examination proved the “gibberish” was actually a quote from Scripture, spoken in the peculiar dialect of this man, who lived many miles away. The phrase being shouted in derision was “*You have been purchased,*” a reference to 1 Corinthians 6:20.

While still in seminary, I heard the story of an American minister praying in tongues that visiting worshipers recognized as their own language: Chinese. But while the minister was using Chinese syllables, he was stringing them together in ways of unique beauty and originality, forming complex sentences of praise to God, which the Chinese Christians themselves had never thought of using.

Episcopalian minister Dennis Bennett has a man in his church in Seattle, Washington, whose prayer language has been identified as Mandarin Chinese. Father Bennett described, in his parish newsletter of April 12, 1967, a most striking example of tongues proving to be a known language. He writes:

A pastor in Oregon tells me of a young Japanese woman married to a young American in his congregation. The Japanese girl had never accepted Christ, but came to the altar of the church with her husband—he to worship God; she to pray to Buddha! Just recently, my friend tells me, as the couple knelt at the altar in his church, a woman next to them began to speak in tongues. The Japanese girl clutched her husband’s arm. “Listen,” she said. The woman next to them was speaking Japanese, and through her, God said, “You have tried Buddha and he has not helped you; why don’t you try Jesus Christ?” God addressed this Japanese girl by her full name, known to no one in this country, and certainly not to the woman speaking, who had no idea how she was being used. Not only that, but the Japanese girl told my pastor friend, “She was speaking high Japanese, the very formal language which we only use in our temples and places like that.”

Many, many other illustrations of a like nature could be included here, but these should be sufficient for us to see that, yes, speaking in tongues today can be in a known language. But again, let us stress that this fact in no way verifies the authenticity of speaking in tongues. It is still a miraculous gift of the Holy Spirit, even in the majority of cases where no one is present who can identify the language.

TWENTY-FIVE

Is the desire to speak in tongues uncontrollable?

This question presupposes a fear similar to that expressed in chapter 23, and a part of the answer is to be found there. So, re-read the answer to that question. Through erroneous teaching, many people have been led to believe that the Holy Spirit “makes people do things they don’t want to do.” They seem to assume that the human will and personality are completely shoved aside, or that they are powerless in the grip of the Holy Spirit, and are quite surprised to learn how gentle the Holy Spirit is in His dealings with us.

Speaking in tongues is a method of prayer and praise, and the one doing the praying is as much in control of his speaking as he is when he is praying in English, that is, he starts or stops at will and decides if and when he is to speak. The Scriptures make this obvious since Paul gives the Corinthian Christians clear instructions as to when and where to speak in tongues, advice which would have been useless unless the person himself has complete control.

If any speak in a tongue, let there be only two or at most three, and each in turn; and let one interpret. But if there is no one to interpret, let each of them keep silence in church and speak to himself and to God. (1 Corinthians 14:27–28)

These verses make it plain that it is up to the person to decide whether or not to speak, and, if he decides to speak in tongues, whether or not it will be aloud or only to himself.

Therefore, we see the desire to speak in tongues is *never* uncontrollable.

TWENTY-SIX

Do you know what you are saying when you speak in tongues?

No, not unless you are given the interpretation by the Holy Spirit. The “*other tongues*,” which the 120 began to speak at Pentecost, were unknown to them but recognizable to the amazed listeners who, according to Scripture, were devout Jews from “*every nation under heaven*.”

And they were amazed and wondered, saying, “Are not all these who are speaking Galileans? And how is it that we hear, each of us in his own native language?...We hear them telling in our own tongues the mighty works of God.”

(Acts 2:7–8, 11)

So, not only did the 120 not know the languages with which they were praising God, but the amazed listeners *knew* they didn’t know what they were saying. For them, this was proof of the miraculous nature of the experience.

When we are worshiping in the Spirit or praying in tongues in our private devotions, there is generally no need for interpretation. This form of prayer is not exercised for the benefit of the intellect. Paul said, “*For if I pray in a tongue, my spirit prays but my mind is unfruitful*” (1 Corinthians 14:14). The Holy Spirit knows the content of our prayer for He inspires it; there is no need for us to understand. It is enough to know that God does.

Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness; for we do not know how to pray as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with sighs too deep for words...because the Spirit intercedes for the saints according to the will of God.

(Romans 8:26–27)

TWENTY-SEVEN

Why hasn't the gift of tongues been mentioned in the great revivals of the past?

The gift of tongues has been prominent in some great revivals of the past, barely mentioned in some, and ignored or disparaged in others. In the great Pentecostal outpouring that began in the first decade of the twentieth century, speaking in tongues was the most talked about and controversial feature in the revival. This revival, which caught fire in the famed Azusa Street Mission in Los Angeles in 1906, gave birth to a number of the strong Pentecostal denominations in our country today.

But there is real spiritual truth in the statement: "What we receive from God is determined by what we expect from Him." In many an earlier revival, though there were great manifestations of God's power, few people expected speaking in tongues to appear and few people saw them. Still, there are accounts of the revivals of John Wesley, Dwight Moody, Charles Finney, and others that take note of speaking in tongues, although they never played a prominent part.

The *Encyclopedia Britannica* states that speaking in tongues has recurred in Christian revivals of every age. There is also evidence in the reports of some revivals that where speaking in tongues appeared, they were squelched as emotionalism—even though shouting, laughing, crying, dancing and trembling, even rolling on the floor were considered "genuine" signs of the Holy Spirit's working. It also seems apparent that speaking in tongues was in evidence in other revivals where singing and laughing in the Spirit were heard, but that the speaking in tongues simply passed unrecognized.

who are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!

(Luke 11:11–13)

As Jesus' earthly ministry drew to a close and He met with the disciples for the last time in the upper room, His instructions to them were liberally laced with promises of the coming of the Holy Spirit.

And I will pray the Father, and he will give you another Counselor, to be with you forever, even the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees him nor knows him; you know him, for he dwells with you, and will be in you. (John 14:16–17)

These things I have spoken to you, while I am still with you. But the Counselor, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, he will teach you all things, and bring to your remembrance all that I have said to you. (John 14:25–26)

But when the Counselor comes, whom I shall send you from the Father, even the Spirit of truth, who proceeds from the Father, he will bear witness to me. (John 15:26)

Nevertheless I tell you the truth: it is to your advantage that I go away, for if I do not go away, the Counselor will not come to you; but if I go, I will send him to you. And when he comes, he will convince the world of sin and of righteousness and of judgment. (John 16:7–8)

I have yet many things to say to you, but you cannot bear them now. When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth; for he will not speak on his own authority, but whatever he hears he will speak; and he will declare to you the things which are to come. He will glorify me, for he will take what is mine and declare it to you. (John 16:12–14)

Then, after Jesus' death and resurrection and before His ascension, He gives His disciples repeated assurances of the coming of the Holy Spirit with power, even as He had promised:

And behold, I send the promise of my Father upon you; but stay in the city, until you are clothed with power from on high. (Luke 24:49)

And while staying with them He charged them not to depart from Jerusalem, but to wait for the promise of the Father, which, He said, "you heard from me, for John baptized with water, but before many days you shall be baptized with the Holy Spirit." So when they had come together, they asked him, "Lord, will you at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?" He said to them, "It is not for you to know the times or seasons which the Father has fixed by his own authority. But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in Judea and Samaria and to the end of the earth." (Acts 1:4–8)

And these signs will accompany those who believe: in my name they will cast out demons; they will speak in new tongues...they will lay their hands on the sick, and they will recover.

(Mark 16:17)

It is significant to note that the very last statements Jesus made to His disciples before His ascension to the Father were about the power they were to receive from the baptism in the Holy Spirit (see Acts 1:8) and the miraculous signs that

baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. And when Paul had laid his hands upon them, the Holy Spirit came on them; and they spoke with tongues and prophesied. (Acts 19:1–6)

In addition to the Scriptures quoted here, 1 Corinthians chapters 12 and 14 deal at length with the nine spiritual gifts that become available to the Christian once he is baptized in the Holy Spirit.

THIRTY

How can I become worthy to receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit?

You can't. There is no way to become worthy. The gift of the Holy Spirit, like the gift of salvation, cannot be earned; it can only be received by faith. It is not bestowed as a prize nor handed out like wages earned. If you could become good enough to earn it, you wouldn't need it! The idea that we earn God's gifts by our good behavior is a great stumbling block to receiving spiritual power today. The only righteousness available to you and me is the righteousness imputed to us *because of our faith in Jesus Christ*. "*For we hold that a man is justified by faith apart from works of law*" (Romans 3:28). The old heresy of salvation by works often rears its ugly head to rob the Christian of God's promised gifts. What Paul says about Israel is true of many well-meaning church members today who are relying on their good behavior to save them.

I bear them witness that they have a zeal for God, but it is not enlightened. For, being ignorant of the righteousness that comes from God, and seeking to establish their own, they did not submit to God's righteousness. For Christ is the end of the law, that everyone who has faith may be justified.
(Romans 10:2–4)

It is not our good works but our faith in Jesus Christ that saves us. Redemption is ours, not by *trying* but by *trusting*. In the same manner, it is by simple trust in God's promise, and not by striving to be "worthy," that we receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit. Sometimes, we hear people say, "Well, I'm just waiting until God decides to give me the Holy Spirit," or, "God will baptize me with the Holy Spirit when He decides I'm worthy." Such people could not be more mistaken! They are being robbed of God's blessing by their own ignorance. Baptism in the Holy Spirit is immediately available to all who humbly and sincerely ask in faith.

THIRTY-ONE

What are the hindrances to receiving the baptism in the Holy Spirit?

Obviously, there are many hindrances if one is not in a right relationship with Jesus Christ. Unconfessed sin, unchristian attitudes or practices, involvement in religious cults that deny the divinity of Christ, fear, or an unforgiving spirit, all are severe hindrances. But I am assuming that this question comes from one who is a Christian in a right relationship with the Lord and who earnestly desires to receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit.

Experience shows that there are two major hindrances that block receptivity to the baptism in the Holy Spirit. The first is scriptural ignorance. For years, the biblical doctrine of the Holy Spirit has been glossed over or ignored by our ministers and Bible teachers. Most Christians are still in the dark concerning what the Bible says about the Holy Spirit and His power. Once the same amount of study and discussion has been given to the Scriptures dealing with the baptism in the Holy Spirit as the Scriptures dealing with baptism in water, we will have much more helpful literature on the subject. People will not ask for spiritual power they do not know exists. Many of us are still like the Ephesian disciples who told Paul, *“No, we have never even heard that there is a Holy Spirit”* (Acts 19:2). Today, with the increasing spread of the charismatic revival, we are witnessing a return to biblical studies on the subject and a heartening decline in biblical ignorance.

But years of wrong teaching and biblical ignorance also leave a psychological barrier that creates difficulty in receiving the baptism, even after we are intellectually convinced it is real. We must cry out like the father of the epileptic boy, *“I believe; help my unbelief!”* (Mark 9:24).

The other major hindrance is fear of what others may think or say—fear of public opinion. Until we want the Holy Spirit more than we want the approval of our fellow church members; until we want the power of God more than we want respectability; until we are so spiritually hungry we don’t really care what other people think, we may not find ourselves very receptive. Most of us have wanted God on our terms and have steadfastly refused to let Him have us on His terms. For this reason, we find it difficult to move into new spiritual experiences. Many people seem to have arrived at the conclusion that speaking in tongues is somehow improper for proper, orthodox church members. Perhaps the basic question we need to ask ourselves is whether we want to be prim, proper, and powerless, or faithful, yielded, and powerful. It seems well-nigh impossible to be both.

THIRTY-TWO

If the baptism in the Holy Spirit comes from God, shouldn't it be spontaneous? Why the necessity for instructions in how to receive it?

We don't think it strange to help people in receiving Christ as Savior by outlining for them the "steps to salvation." How many millions of brochures and tracts do you suppose have been distributed on "How to be saved"? This doesn't mean that people earn salvation or that it is not a sovereign act of God's grace. Neither does it mean that people cannot find salvation while reading the Word of God alone, with no human help. But we do know that information can be furnished that will help the inquirer to accept Jesus Christ as Lord and Savior.

The same is true with baptism in the Holy Spirit. If we were as unbiased in our thinking about the Holy Spirit as the first Christians were, perhaps there would be less need for instruction. But most of us have erroneous teaching and ingrown prejudice to overcome. So instructions are given to help undo false teaching and make people more receptive to encounter Jesus as the baptizer in the Holy Spirit.

The Scriptures make it plain that in seeking the blessings of God, *how* we ask is as important as *what* we ask for. Jesus gave instruction to the disciples in matters pertaining to prayer. And if we examine the Scriptures closely, we find evidence of Jesus teaching the disciples about the coming of the Holy Spirit. Even the experience of Pentecost may not have been as spontaneous as it first appears since Jesus may have told his disciples to expect the manifestation of tongues that came at Pentecost. Certainly, He mentioned tongues as one of the miraculous signs that would follow those who believed: *"And these signs will follow those who believe: in my name they will cast out demons; **they will speak in new tongues**"* (Mark 16:17, emphasis added), and He made this statement just before His ascension, only ten days before Pentecost.

THIRTY-FOUR

How can I know that what I receive is the baptism in the Holy Spirit and not a counterfeit from Satan?

If you are sincere and honest in seeking a blessing from the Lord, you need have no fear of a counterfeit from Satan. If you ask God for the baptism in the Holy Spirit, then that's what you receive. We have Jesus' own word for it.

What father among you, if his son asks for a fish, will instead of a fish give him a serpent; or if he asks for an egg, will give him a scorpion? If you then, who are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!

(Luke 11:11–13)

What could be plainer than that? Jesus said that if the Father didn't keep His Word, He would be less than an evil man, for even an evil man knows how to give good gifts to his children.

The fear of a counterfeit is one of Satan's favorite tricks to discourage sincere Christians from seeking all God has for them. I cannot make the emphasis strong enough when I say that God's Word is to be trusted! Wholly. Completely. Implicitly. God *cannot* deny Himself. He *cannot* deny His own Word. If you ask for a blessing from God, He *cannot* respond with a counterfeit from Satan.

When this question arises—as it often does—in sessions where we are about to pray for people to receive the baptism, we answer in this way: “We’re going to pray now that the Lord Jesus Christ will baptize every one of you in the Holy Spirit. We want each of you to accept—by faith—that from this point on everything that happens is of the Holy Spirit.”

I’ve had the privilege of praying for many hundreds of people to receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit, and I’ve never yet seen anyone receive a counterfeit. And I don’t believe I ever will.

THIRTY-FIVE

Where should I go to receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit?

No one place is better than any other. People have received the baptism in Pentecostal tent meetings, in all kinds of churches, including Episcopal and Roman Catholic churches, in prayer meetings, in homes, and in almost every conceivable circumstance. I know of a minister who received it while preparing a sermon in his study; and another minister who received it while preaching to his congregation. I know Christians who have received while driving a car, while lying in bed, even while taking a bath. My own brother, a colonel in the Air Force, received the baptism in the Holy Spirit as we sat praying together in a parked station wagon on a deer ranch in South Texas.

Just a few months ago, my wife and I prayed two young men through to the baptism in the Holy Spirit in our own station wagon in Atlanta, Georgia, as they waited to catch a plane. The plane was delayed for three hours, and I believe God did it in order that time might be made available for us to counsel and pray with those men. Another young friend received the baptism while traveling with a touring choir in Italy. Strange as it seems, she received the Holy Spirit and began praising God quietly in tongues as she stood with several hundred other people in St. Peter's Cathedral in Rome, during an audience with the Pope.

You see, it isn't the *place* you're in that's important; it's the *state* you're in that counts. If you are trustfully and prayerfully seeking this deeper experience with God, it can happen anywhere.

But having shared these incidents, let me hasten to encourage you to seek fellowship in some charismatic church or prayer group where you will find those who have the ministry of helping others to receive. It is most likely that right in your own town or neighborhood there is a church or a house prayer meeting with this ministry.

Yet, if you have difficulty in locating such a group, or if you are one of those shy people who are reluctant to have others pray over you or to receive the laying on of hands, then rest assured that you can receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit alone. In fact, you can receive it before you lay this book down, if you will ask in faith and cooperate with the Holy Spirit. We are not meant to "tarry" or wait, we are meant to believe and receive. The following chapter offers specific steps which can be of help to you if you are ready—right now—to move into this wonderful new relationship with the Lord. Why stand ye here? Jesus is waiting to baptize with power!

was there alone, but the boat by this time was many furlongs distant from the land, beaten by the waves; for the wind was against them. And in the fourth watch of the night he came to them, walking on the sea. But when the disciples saw him walking on the sea, they were terrified, saying, "It is a ghost!" And they cried out for fear. But immediately he spoke to them, saying, "Take heart, it is I; have no fear." And Peter answered him, "Lord, if it is you, bid me come to you on the water." He said, "Come." So Peter got out of the boat and walked on the water and came to Jesus; but when he saw the wind, he was afraid, and beginning to sink he cried out, "Lord, save me." Jesus immediately reached out his hand and caught him, saying to him, "O man of little faith, why did you doubt?" (Matthew 14:22–31)

This Scripture contains the story of how Peter sought and experienced a miracle. It is significant for you, because to receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit and speak in tongues is to experience a miracle. By examining this story and identifying yourself with Peter and his actions, you can be greatly helped to receive.

When Peter saw Jesus approaching on the water he said, "*Lord, **if it is you**, bid me come.*" Peter wanted assurance that the miracle he sought was in accordance with the will of God for his life. Many people today ask, "How do I know that it's God's will that I receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit?" The Scriptures you read about the baptism make it abundantly clear that the Lord *does* desire to bestow this gift on every Christian. So accept His will for you in this matter with joy and anticipation, know that His invitation applies to "**you and to your children and to *all* that are far off**" (Acts 2:39, emphasis added).

Now let us also note that Peter said, "*Lord, if it is you, **bid me come to you on the water.***" Peter *knew* he was asking the Lord for a miracle, asking Him to provide what no man on earth could grant. Only God could provide, by His supernatural power, the means for Peter to walk on the water. By the same token, the baptism in the Holy Spirit and speaking in tongues is a miracle that no man on earth can grant. Only God, by His supernatural power, can fill you with His Holy Spirit and enable you to speak in tongues.

Jesus told Peter to "*Come*" because He knew God's power would sustain Peter on top of the water. Jesus tells you to "Receive" because He knows God's power will fill you and enable you to speak in tongues.

By his willingness to come in response to Jesus' invitation, Peter, in effect, was saying, "Lord, if You say I can do it—if You say I can walk on the water—I trust You to make it possible." So also, you who are seeking the baptism in the Holy Spirit must say, "Lord, if You say I can receive—if You say I can speak in tongues—I trust You to make it possible."

3. Pray the prayer of invitation.

In a simple, fervent prayer, ask Jesus to fill you with the Holy Spirit. You may use a prayer like the following:

Lord Jesus Christ, I believe with all my heart that the baptism in the Holy Spirit is meant for me. Just as I trust You for my eternal salvation, so now do I trust You to give me Your Holy Spirit with the evidence of speaking in tongues. I now open my life to receive the fullness of Your Holy Spirit within. Thank You, Lord Jesus, Amen.

their credulity and serves as too severe a judgment on their own ordinary lives. They often find it impossible to admit the validity of any such experience. They are, to quote Rufus Moseley again, “The hardest nuts to crack and the poorest meat when cracked.”

But just as some of the most likely people seem to be the most vehement in their rejection of our witness, so do some of the most unlikely people turn up as candidates for the baptism in the Holy Spirit. We may be sure, when praying about our witness, that the Holy Spirit knows the very people who will be receptive to our testimony and will see to it that they cross our path.

Third, *don't be in any big rush to change churches*. If your initial attempts to give your witness are met with cool rebuff or even open hostility, you may be strongly tempted to leave your church for some other congregation where you believe people will be more receptive. Go slow! Pray long and hard! Be doubly sure that it is God's will before you make such a move, for if you leave, who will be the witness in your church? Your very difficulties are proof you are needed where you are. The most powerful Christian witness in any congregation may come from the few members who are Spirit-filled, and more than one church has been prayed to life by the earnest intercession of one or two Spirit-filled laymen who resisted the temptation to head for “greener fields” and, instead, opened the way for revival in their own church by the power of their prayers.

Let your experience of the Holy Spirit draw you into deeper and more loving participation in the life of your church, not only with some charismatic group you may join, but in the church's worship and service as well. Other church members, having heard your testimony, will be waiting—and rightly so—to see the fruit of your experience in your actions. And they will be far more impressed with what you share if the experience leads you into a deeper love for the church and its people, than if they see you deserting the church to start off on some tangent of your own.

For the minister receiving the baptism in the Holy Spirit, things may prove somewhat more difficult, depending on the stand of his particular denomination concerning the charismatic revival. It is true that some ministers, on making public their testimony, have been forced to resign. In some cases, this appears inevitable. Perhaps some churches can only be made aware of what God is doing in our day through this kind of open break. But we must also honestly admit to situations where, if the minister had been a little less precipitous, if he had been just a little more loving and a little more patient, his testimony would have been accepted by some and perhaps tolerated by all.

Of course, we recognize that every situation must be judged on its own merits, and there is no way of predicting how the Holy Spirit will move and what the reaction to His moving will be in every case. But one thing seems clear: if we are patient, faithful, and trusting, God will open a way for our testimony, either where we presently are or in some situation to which He will lead us.

A fourth word of advice: *be careful, but be a witness!* At the opposite end of being too bold and premature in witnessing, there is the equal, if not greater, danger of silencing our witness. I am especially sensitive to this sin, not only because I was personally guilty of it (the result being several years of relatively fruitless ministry), but also because of the increasing number of Christians who